

anyway. In *God of War*, you play god-killer Kratos as he slices and dices his way through the entire Greek pantheon. The game unravels a rich tapestry of Greek mythology for you to spill blood on. Butt heads with every monster imagined therein, from a hydra to winged harpies. It's very satisfying to meet all this rich culture with a bloodied weapon. The combat is not very deep, though. Combos are simple to execute, and are unlocked by collecting red orbs to power up your weapons. Joining the blades of chaos are a bunch of spells and one obligatory oversized sword. *God of War*, however, balances good combat with a great production value and some challenging puzzles. It also uses mini-games to great effect: successfully hit a combination of keys shown on-screen, and you will shove your weapon down a Minotaur's throat, or tear off a Medusa's head. It's all very touching. How can you say no?

Shadow Of The Colossus

Battle and fell mighty colossi in this epic action-adventure to save the love of your life. Journey on horseback through a vast empty world in which you have no enemies to destroy, no dungeons to pillage, nothing much to do but fight the game's sixteen colossi. You race



across silence and a barren landscape until you encounter these wonderfully-designed beasts. You then need to kill what is most alive in this strange, dead world. Each colossus is a behemoth—huge and threatening, with unique weaknesses and attack patterns.

The game explains little of motive or backstory, and you can't help feel a little deprived for the killing. *Shadow of the Colossus* is truly a unique experience.

Guitar Hero

This game is a gift from rock-n-roll. It is an axe from heaven to cleave asunder the mediocrity that passes for music today. Ahem! With *Guitar Hero*, you can play tracks from Black Sabbath, Red Hot Chili Peppers, Queen,



Pantera, Megadeth, Judas Priest, Ozzy Osbourne, White Zombie, The Ramones, David Bowie, Jimi Hendrix, ZZ Top and more—for a total of 47 playable covers and indie tracks! The rocking is done to a custom game controller in the shape of a mini Gibson SG. The designers of this gem have clearly learned their rock and roll well: *Guitar Hero* takes you across six venues—from your basement to sold-out arenas, as you play using one of eight characters with unique looks and playing styles, and pick up from among 10 guitars that you can customise with 28 unlockable skins. *Guitar Hero* also lets you battle it out with one more player for the attention of a crowd, with only Rock and Roll as your weapon. You too can be a guitar god. Are You Ready To Rooooooooock?

Katamari Damacy

Imagine yourself as a tiny green thing with an unfortunate head. Now imagine yourself holding a small ball that resembles a reject set-piece from *Johnny Sokko and the Giant Robot*. Imagine rolling that ball over a paper clip, then over an eraser, then a pencil, then a ruler, then a book, then a kitten, and so on, until you're rolling over the table, then the house, then the trees, the cars, some unfortunate onlookers—and you keep rolling and rolling and rolling... like a dung-beetle making an unfortunate statement on consumerism! You roll your *Damacy* over everyday objects in order to create balls of certain diameters, which can then be used to order to restore the stars and galaxies. Yeah. The game works because it is fun and has plenty of charm and personality. With an excellent presentation, a funky soundtrack, simple play mechanics, and challenging levels—*Katamari Damacy* is the hallmark of a good, fun game. It is also an ideal vehicle to bring that girl you fancy to your gaming frat house—chicks dig *Katamari*.

Metal Gear Solid 3: Subsistence

Metal Gear Solid 3 is difficult to pin down in 200 words or less. It is a stealth game, yes. It has you playing as a super-secret spy called Snake; stalking baddies through jungles, to stop suitably diabolical plans. Fairly typical fare on the surface, but the game is a master-